colorful echoes of the grandeur of the Taj[20]. It would appear that Shah Jahan had the mausoleums of saintly women like these in mind when he ordered the construction of his wife's final resting place.

Indian and Turkic Influence

Despite the assertions of some far-right Indian nationalists, the Taj Mahal is fundamentally a Persian Muslim building. However, the builders had already begun to draw in Hindu influences, most notably the Indian architectural school of Vastu Shastra, and Shah Jahan's mother was a Hindu from Rajasthan.

Part of this influence is the rectilinear layout: the Taj's central structure has four equal sides, each with a gate and smaller gates at the corners. While the exterior of the building has a prominent central gate overlooking the gardens that is featured in innumerable pictures, the interior is purely symmetrical. In this way it appears to resemble a Hindu Temple, as Vastu Shastra teaches about a balance between four elements through rectilinear structures. In contrast, the contemporary Mughal Mosque of the Jama Masjid in Delhi has an axis directed toward Mecca and is not symmetrical[21]. Likewise, the Taj appears to follow the Vastu Shastra teaching that the height and width of the building should correspond to each other, a harmoniousness that allows the outer towers to stand out visually and add to the striking appearance of the exterior[22]. Other Hindu elements brought into the structure include the use of the four chatris (small domed pavilions standing on pillars) alongside the primary dome.